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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Senate confirms Patel to lead FBI

51-49 vote installs president loyalist, fierce agency critic

By Eric Tucker
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — The Senate on Thursday narrowly voted to confirm Kash Patel as director of the FBI, moving to place him atop the nation’s premier federal law enforcement agency despite doubts from Democrats about his qualifications and concerns he will

do Donald Trump’s bidding and go after the Republican president’s adversaries.

“I cannot imagine a worse choice,” Sen. Dick Durbin, D-Ill., told colleagues before the 51-49 vote by the GOP-controlled Senate. Sens. Susan Collins of Maine and Lisa Murkowski of Alaska were the lone Republican holdouts.

A Trump loyalist who has fiercely criticized the agency, Patel will inherit an FBI gripped by turmoil as the Justice Department over the past month has forced out a group of senior bureau offi-

INSIDE: Trump targets officials who flagged foreign interference in U.S. elections. **Nation & World**

cials and made a highly unusual demand for the names of thousands of agents who participated in investigations related to the Jan. 6, 2021, riot at the U.S. Capitol.

Patel has spoken of his desire to implement major changes at the FBI, including a reduced footprint at headquarters in Washington and a renewed emphasis on the bureau’s traditional crime-fight-

ing duties rather than the intelligence-gathering and national security work that has come to define its mandate over the past two decades.

But he also echoed Trump’s desire for retribution. Patel raised alarm among Democrats for saying before he was nominated that he would “come after” anti-Trump “conspirators” in the federal government and the media.

In a statement posted after the vote on the social media platform

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Kash Patel appears before the Senate Judiciary Committee on Jan. 30 in a confirmation hearing at the Capitol. **BEN CURTIS/AP**



ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

City clears some tents at Gompers Park

Phill, last name withheld, steps out of his tent as police officers arrive at the homeless encampment in Gompers Park on Wednesday. The city began removing some tents this week and the future of the roughly 20 people in the encampment remains uncertain. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

In wake of bankruptcy, vacant lots up for sale

Community advocates on South, West sides eyeing redevelopment

By Brian J. Rogal
Chicago Tribune

Hundreds of vacant lots in Chicago, many in South and West side neighborhoods such as Englewood and North Lawndale, have been put on the market in the largest such land sale the city has seen in recent years. The lots, some of which were in poor condition, have been listed for sale as part of bankruptcy proceedings involving a pair of property owners who amassed \$15 million in unpaid fines on the land parcels, and who city lawyers have deemed Chicago’s “worst landowner.”

Community advocates say it’s a chance to get the properties into the hands of fresh owners who can fill the empty spaces with new homes, businesses or affordable apartments.

“It’s all up for grabs, and I think everyone in Englewood is following it,” said Felicia Slaton-Young, executive director of the Greater Englewood Chamber of Commerce. “Some of the properties are along commercial corridors, and it’s negatively impacted Englewood because these owners

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Chicago resident Robin Moore, center, smiles as her son, Andrew Harris, left, reacts after Moore finished her speech about her family history in Canada at the Consulate General of Canada on Feb. 12 in Chicago. **CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Uncovering a family mystery

How woman’s genealogical search led her to a potter’s field in Canada

By Carolyn Stein
Chicago Tribune

Robin Moore initially had one purpose: learn more about the life of her grandfather Reginald Moore. She remembered him as a very loving and hardworking person, but details surrounding his early life remained a family mystery — one that she was determined to uncover.

She never expected that mission to take her to a grassy field in a remote part of Canada, where several of her ancestors are buried.

Since 2018, Moore — a native of Park Manor on Chicago’s South Side — has spent much of her free time combing through archival records and building a family tree to better understand her roots. The genealogical proj-

ect has taken her all the way to a cemetery in a small town in Canada, located about two hours west of Toronto.

“The Canadian heritage has always been known,” Moore said, noting that her father’s parents were born in Canada and that she frequently visits the Maple Leaf Country. Now that she’s older and started

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Johnson rips ethics reform proposal

Plan was recommended as way to prevent mayors from impeding inquiries

By Jake Sheridan
Chicago Tribune

Mayor Brandon Johnson on Thursday ripped a proposal Chicago’s top independent watchdog recommended as a way to prevent him and future mayors from impeding investigations by her office.

The mayor’s condemnation of the ordinance came a day after his close ally, Ald. Byron Sigcho-Lopez, stalled it when it was introduced to the City Council.

The legislation matched recommendations Inspector General Deborah Witzburg made in a recent letter to aldermen as she criticized the mayor-controlled Law Department for hindering investigations that “may result in embarrassment or political consequences to City leaders.”

Witzburg said the Law Department has selectively slow-walked compliance with inspector general subpoenas. She asked aldermen to change city law to clearly eliminate the department’s discretion over subpoena enforcement.

But when Ald. Matt Martin, the City Council’s Ethics Committee chair, introduced legislation to do that on Wednesday, Sigcho-Lopez sent it to the Rules Committee — which is where mayors and their allies often ship legislation they oppose to languish.

Johnson’s administration marked its clear opposition to Martin’s proposal Thursday, saying in a statement, “this ordinance is not an ethics reform ordinance.”

“The proposed ordinance is legally deficient on its face and requires further scrutiny in the Rules Committee where it can be properly vetted and analyzed,” Johnson spokesperson Cassio Mendoza wrote. The package appears to conflict with state law, city code and Illinois Supreme Court precedent, he added.

Witzburg called the claim that the ordinance needed to be delayed “disingenuous” Thursday. Her office has long sought the change, even pushing for it when Lori Lightfoot was mayor and with

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INSIDE

‘We intend on being good this year’

Justin Turner’s arrival took center stage at Cubs camp, thanks to his reputation and clubhouse presence. **Chicago Sports**

Pipeline replacement project can resume

Regulators say Peoples Gas can continue the program, but with narrowed focus, faster timeline and greater accountability. **Business**

